

TECH THAT HEALS

Wearable gadgets are the next big thing, and equipped with sensors that help track our health, they're the key to a healthy life in the modern age

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While technology's overdose is clearly unsettling our physiological and psychological constitution, there's no reason to feel our cause is doomed, that our existence is threatened, or fear us devolving into lesser beings. Just as Kartik's misgivings about the ill-effects of an overdependence on technology were steeped in reality, so is another inevitable truth from which there's no running away: Technology can break us, and there's technology that can fix us too. Here's how 21st century technology is helping us solve a 21st century health problem.

Gadgets to the rescue

Living a healthy lifestyle is easier than ever before thanks to an array of wearable devices (paired with fitness apps) and other specialty smart products that let you track your health better than ever before. The best part about these innovations are that they're quite affordable, being almost as expensive or cheaper to that next smartphone you're eying for purchase. If you care for your health, wearables can help you track it better.

We're glad to say that the recent explosion of wearable technology is leading the charge of getting consumer technology into the profitable and underserved



Wearable wristbands, smartwatches are bringing technology and health closer together

healthcare sector. The smartphone and tablets boom is over, and most of these products are fast getting commoditized. However, leveraging their widespread appeal, hardware firepower, and established ecosystem are a new wave of connected devices that aren't much more than accessories. They're small, unobtrusive, portable and easy to not notice – but equipped with special sensors, these wearable gadgets are leading the charge of democratizing healthcare, giving you

the tools and means to monitor and track your health, and in some cases even offer advice (like a doctor would).

Not just gadgets made out of metal or plastic, but smart clothes – socks and shirts, smart beds, and other non-traditional avenues of technological application is being witnessed. Given this new reality that's staring us in the face, and the ease of using devices without making an effort (in a way), this is enhancing the appeal of wearables. And its application in the personal healthcare sector is a natural evolution of the segment.

What's more, equipped with geeky, cool-looking wearable devices that double up as fitness trackers and activity monitors, getting in shape was never more fashionable. If you've seen gymnasiums and joggers' park, you'd know what we mean. When the world around you is slowly waking up to the reality of leading a healthier life by harnessing day-to-day technology, what's stopping you from taking the plunge? 

FUTURE OF WEARABLES AND HEALTHCARE

U.K.-based Juniper Research is expecting the number of wearable devices shipped will rise from about 13 million in 2013 to 130 million in 2018, and market to jump from \$1.4 billion in 2013 to \$19 billion in 2018. There are reports predicting shipments of between 90 to 100 million pieces of wearable gadgets in 2014 alone. But how many of these will impact the personal healthcare market? Just to give you an idea, according to a GigaOm report, ABI Research estimates the global market for wearables in health and fitness could reach up to 170 million devices by 2017. With such high stakes and big money on the line, it's safe to assume that wearable tech isn't a fad, but a reality from this year onwards. And its inclination towards the health sector is quite natural and all but stands to revolutionize the personal healthcare system around the world.